INTERVIEW

"IT WILL ENHANCE INDIA'S STRATEGIC PRESENCE AND STRENGTHEN ITS TRADING POSITION"

Soon after the National Green Tribunal delivered its verdict clearing the Great Nicobar Project, Union Minister of Environment, Forest and Climate Change BHUPENDER YADAV agreed to an email interview with INDIA TODAY outlining its importance and what his ministry is doing to balance development with protecting the island's fragile environment. Excerpts:



Photographs by ARUN KUMAR

Q. What is the strategic and economic rationale for going ahead with the Great Nicobar Project despite concerns over the destruction of the island's virgin ecosystems?

The Great Nicobar Project is an integrated development plan on about 1.8 per cent of the Andaman & Nicobar Island region designed to transform Great Nicobar Island (GNI) into a major hub of maritime and air connectivity in the Indian Ocean Region. The project is of great defence, national security and strategic significance. It will strengthen India's presence in the Andaman Sea and Southeast Asia and create an economic hub with a major transhipment terminal. The project offers immense opportunities to further strengthen India's trading position in the world, particularly by developing a competitive international transhipment port at GNI, which has locational advantages over competing ports in the Bay of Bengal region. The airport is planned as a joint military-civil dual-use facility under the operational control of the Indian Navy, thereby directly contributing to defence preparedness. This will enable India to effectively monitor and secure maritime routes and counter the growing presence of foreign powers in the Indian Ocean.